Rhetorical & Stylistic Devices

Concept

A device is a deliberate language choice. Explain what it emphasizes, how it shapes a response, and why it suits the purpose.

Effect depends on context

A device may clarify, persuade, entertain, create rhythm or draw attention. Avoid memorizing one fixed effect.

Analysis pattern

Device + exact detail + specific effect + connection to purpose.

Ethos / pathos / logos

Additional guide: credibility, emotional appeal and reasoning. A device may support more than one appeal.

Precision

Identify the actual pattern. Repeated words at the start are anaphora; repeated conjunctions are polysyndeton.

Example 1 | original model

Original sentence: "We need time to listen, time to question, time to change."

Solution / why it works

1. Pattern: repeated "time to" at the start of successive phrases = anaphora.
2. Structure: the three phrases use matching grammar = parallelism.
3. Effect: the repetition makes a three-part call to action memorable and gives equal weight to each step.

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Example 2 | original model

Compare: “We packed, ran, waited.” / “We packed and ran and waited.”

Solution / why it works

1. First: asyndeton omits conjunctions and can create a brisk, compressed pace.

2. Second: polysyndeton repeats and, giving each action emphasis and potentially slowing the sequence.

3. The actual effect depends on the surrounding passage and how it is read.

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Reference | Repetition, balance & arrangement

Alliteration

Repeated initial consonant sounds: bright blue banners.

Assonance

Repeated vowel sounds: pale rain.

Anaphora

Repeated openings: We listen. We learn. We act.

Antimetabole

Words repeat in reverse order: We shape habits; habits shape us.

Antithesis

Balanced contrast: A quiet voice can carry a powerful message.

Parallelism

Matching grammar for related ideas: to read, to question, to revise.

Asyndeton

Conjunctions are omitted: She read, questioned, revised.

Polysyndeton

Conjunctions are repeated: She read and questioned and revised.

Periodic sentence

The main clause arrives near the end: After the noise faded and the doors closed, she spoke.

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Juxtaposition

Things placed close together invite comparison: a new tower beside a ruined cottage.

Closing by return

An ending returns to an opening image or idea.

Framing words

Signals mark the structure or relationship of ideas: first, moreover, therefore.

Flow

Coherence and continuity among sentences and paragraphs.

Zeugma

One word links multiple elements, sometimes in different senses: She lost her keys and her patience.

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Reference | Comparison, association & imagery

Allusion

A reference relies on the audience recognizing another text, event or tradition.

Analogy

A comparison explains an unfamiliar idea through a more familiar relationship.

Simile

A comparison using like or as: the crowd moved like a tide.

Metaphor

A non-literal comparison: the crowd was a tide.

Personification

Human qualities are given to non-human things: the alarm protested.

Figurative language

Language extends beyond literal meaning through techniques such as metaphor or hyperbole.

Imagery

Sensory language evokes sight, sound, touch, taste or smell.

Symbol

Something represents a meaning beyond its literal role, supported by context.

Metonymy

An associated thing substitutes for another: the bench for the judiciary.

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Synecdoche

A part substitutes for a whole: wheels for a car.

Connotation

Emotional or cultural associations beyond a word's denotation.

Euphemism

A milder expression softens a difficult subject: passed away for died.

Oxymoron

Apparently contradictory terms together: a familiar stranger.

Hyperbole

Deliberate exaggeration: I have a mountain of homework.

Understatement

Deliberately reduced emphasis: a shattered vase is "a little damaged."

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Reference | Voice, persuasion & audience

Anecdote

A short incident illustrates a point or creates a personal connection.

Colloquialism

Conversational wording such as "a bit"; suitable register depends on audience.

Hortative sentence

Urges or encourages action: Let us give everyone a chance to speak.

Imperative sentence

Commands or requests: Read the final paragraph again.

Rhetorical question

A question used for effect or thought rather than a literal answer.

Irony

A meaningful gap between literal wording and intention, expectation and outcome, or audience and character knowledge.

Satire

Uses humour, irony or exaggeration to criticize faults or institutions.

Tone

The speaker's or writer's attitude toward the subject or audience.

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Word bank | Tone vocabulary

Satiric	Disdainful	Compassionate
Whimsical	Pedantic	Impartial
Dramatic	Indignant	Pretentious
Learned	Bantering	Vibrant
Informative	Flippant	Sentimental
Sombre	Patronizing	Moralistic
Urgent	Mock-serious	Taunting
Confident	Benevolent	Angry
Objective	Burlesque	Turgid
Diffident	Fanciful	Insolent
Ironic	Detached	Condescending
Didactic	Cynical	Sympathetic
Petty	Scornful	Inflammatory
Factual	Effusive	Candid
Restrained	Colloquial	

Rhetorical & Stylistic Devices

Practice | your turn

1. Identify the device: “She lost her keys and her patience.”

2. Write one example of antithesis using parallel grammar.

3. Find a device in your class reading and explain its specific effect in two sentences.

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Sample answers | check after trying

Writing tasks can have more than one strong answer. Use these models and checks to review your work.

1

Zeugma: lost links a literal object (keys) and an abstract state (patience).

2

Possible example: We can build bridges, or we can build barriers. The parallel clauses sharpen the contrast.

3

Avoid "it interests the reader" alone. Explain what is emphasized and how it supports the passage's purpose.

Source & editing note

rhetorical-and-stylistic-devices.pdf | 4 supplied pages.

No author identified in the supplied handout. Concepts reorganized and condensed; repeated templates consolidated. Examples, practice and sample answers here are original additions, not copied student work.